support. But given the trouble he was already having holding his new conquests in Peshawar, Ranjit had little enthusiasm for Lord Auckland's invitation to invade Kabul. Keen to get rid of Dost Mohammad, and seeing opportunities to increase his wealth in the process, but unwilling to get entangled in Afghanistan, he played his hand with consummate skill.

In early June, Macnaghten reported discouragingly that Ranjit 'would not dream of marching a force to Kabul'.[119] Slowly, however, the Maharajah made it clear that he might be open to persuasion, hinting that if he were given the financial centre of Shikarpur, the Khyber and Jalalabad he might be prepared to join a punitive expedition to chastise and unseat his old Afghan enemy. Macnaghten refused, and for a fortnight the talks were deadlocked. In reality, Ranjit was probably only using these demands as a bargaining counter. For when he gave in and said that he now only wanted to be confirmed for perpetuity in possession of Peshawar and Kashmir, to receive £20,000 from the British as well as a large cash payment from the Amirs of Sindh, and for Shah Shuja in addition to pay him an annual tribute including '55 high bred horses of approved colour and pleasant paces', camel loads of 'musk melons of sweet and delicate flavour' and '101 Persian carpets', Macnaghten accepted the offer immediately, and promised to press Shuja and the amirs to deliver. As the negotiations inched forward, what had originally been planned as a Sikh expedition in British interests slowly began to transform itself over the course of several weeks into a British expedition to further Sikh interests.

Only at the end of June, after the negotiations had moved to Lahore, and Burnes and Masson had joined the British delegation from Peshawar, was it confirmed that Ranjit would be prepared to join a largely British force, which together would place Shuja on the throne.

'Your Highness some time ago [in 1834] formed a treaty with Shah Shuja ul-Mulk,' said Macnaghten. 'Do you think it would still be for your benefit that the treaty should stand good, and would it be agreeable to your wishes that the British government become party to that treaty?'

'This', replied Ranjit, 'would be adding sugar to milk.'[120]

Up to this point, no one had thought of informing Shah Shuja that he was imminently to be placed back on his old throne. Nor had Macnaghten, who